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Atmanirbhar Bharat: Security and Prosperity

Understanding the Present

India is entering a decisive period as it defines its role in the world. Its developmental trajectory is positive. Its economy has more than tripled as a share of the world since 1992. Its demographics are entering a period of peak workforce, even as total fertility has begun to fall below replacement levels. The geopolitical environment, while fluid, is far more favourable than in the past, when India had to deal with decolonization and Partition, aid dependence, separatist movements, and major wars without the benefits of food security, a global market and a nuclear deterrent. Diplomatically, India now has a wide variety of partners—including among major powers such as the United States, Europe, Russia, and Japan and countries in the Global South—with which it enjoys largely cooperative and constructive partnerships.

But the world is also changing. The United States remains a major superpower, but there is a growing domestic political consensus in that country around resetting its international obligations and revisiting the terms of globalization. China has risen as a major power in its own right. Although it confronts its fair share of economic and political difficulties, it is focused on displacing the United States as a regional and global power. A long-term great power competition—akin to the Cold War but in a more globalized context—is already underway. Other major economies—including the European Union, United Kingdom, and Japan—are struggling with the challenges of demographics, immigration, slower growth, unsustainable welfare, and military dependence on the United States. Russia is preoccupied with war and has deepened its dependence on China. The